National
Qualifications
2025

2025 ESOL

Reading

Higher

Question Paper Finalised Marking Instructions

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General marking principles for Higher ESOL Reading

Always apply these general principles. Use them in conjunction with the detailed marking instructions, which identify the key features required in candidates' responses.

(a) Always use positive marking. This means candidates accumulate marks for the demonstration of relevant skills, knowledge and understanding; marks are not deducted for errors or omissions.

(b) If a candidate response does not seem to be covered by either the principles or detailed marking instructions, and you are uncertain how to assess it, you must seek guidance from your team leader.

(c) Use your professional judgement, subject knowledge and experience, and understanding to award marks to candidate responses.

(d) The marking instructions indicate the essential idea that a candidate should provide for each answer and there may be variation in candidate responses. Award marks according to the accuracy and relevance of a candidate's answers.

(e) The answers for each question must come from the text. Award marks where the candidate's answer is accurate but expressed in their own words. For open questions requiring short answers, candidates must not lift large chunks of text from the passage. If specific words or phrases from the text are required, candidates must not use paraphrasing.

(f) Where questions require a response of, for example, 'no more than three words', do not penalise candidates if they use an additional word, provided that the essential idea required by the question is correct.

(g) Do not penalise candidates for spelling mistakes so long as the meaning is clear.

(h) Where there is a multiple choice question and the candidate ticks more boxes than required, award **0 marks** where a candidate ticks all boxes. If two answers are required and the candidate ticks three boxes with two correct answers, award **1 mark**. If two answers are required and a candidate ticks three boxes with one correct answer, award **0 marks.**

(i) For overall purpose questions, candidates must draw meaning from their overall understanding of the text.

Marking instructions for each question

Text 1

Question			Expected response(s)	Max mark	Additional guidance
1.			stomach fluttered	**1**	no more than 3 words
2.			awkward	**1**	no more than 3 words **DO NOT ACCEPT** 'awkward silences'
3.			novelty	**1**	**ACCEPT** 'like a novelty'
4.			simple/misconstrued/edited/lost in translation/exhausting	**1**	no more than 3 words
5.			D	**1**	
6.			A	**1**	
7.			B	**1**	
8.	(i)		D	**1**	
	(ii)		B	**1**	
	(iii)		E	**1**	
	(iv)		C	**1**	
9.			C	**1**	

Text 2

Question			Expected response(s)	Max mark	Additional guidance
10.			C	**1**	
11.			B	**1**	
12.			A	**1**	
13.			given the boot	**1**	needs all 3 words
14.			gimmicks	**1**	
15.			fungus	**1**	**ACCEPT** 'fungus growing in the corner'
16.			flip-flops	**1**	**ACCEPT** 'use their flip flops to reach the snack' **DO NOT ACCEPT** 'hands'
17.			proof of ownership	**1**	needs all 3 words no more than 3 words
18.			(never-ending) battle	**1**	no more than 3 words
19.			rakes in	**1**	no more than 3 words **DO NOT ACCEPT** 'rakes'
20.			expansion	**1**	**not** 'top earner' no more than 3 words
21.			substandard set-up	**1**	no more than 3 words **DO NOT ACCEPT** 'cheaply installed' **ACCEPT** 'same substandard set-up'

Text 3

Question			Expected response(s)	Max mark	Additional guidance
22.			community cohesion	**1**	no more than 3 words
23.			marching and skipping	**1**	both required no more than 3 words
24.			continuous improvement	**1**	no more than 3 words a/the commitment
25.			D	**1**	
26.			A	**1**	
27.			B	**1**	
28.			D	**1**	
29.	(i)		C	**1**	
	(ii)		E	**1**	
	(iii)		D	**1**	
30.			C	**1**	

[END OF MARKING INSTRUCTIONS]